The Means of Accomplishing Heruka

Śrīherukasādhana · Toh 1265 · Derge Tengyur

དཔའ་བྱེད་སྒྲུབ་ཐབས།

The Means of Accomplishing Heruka, known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Heruka Sādhana and in Tibetan as Heruké Druptap, is a short ritual manual for the meditative practice of Hevajra in his form with one face and two arms, embraced by his consort Nairātmyā. Composed by the Indian master Sahajavilāsa and translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Balendraruci and the Tibetan translator Maban Chöbar, it guides the yogin through a daily practice: preliminary worship, confession and refuge, the generation of the awakening mind and meditation on emptiness, the visualization of oneself as the deity adorned with the five buddhas, empowerment, the blessing and tasting of nectar, and the recitation of the twelve-syllable mantra. It is Toh 1265 in the Tengyur, where it belongs among the tantra commentaries as one of the many sādhanas associated with the Hevajra cycle.

In the language of India: śrīherukasādhani. In the language of Tibet: The Means of Accomplishing Heruka.

Homage to glorious Vajraḍāka.

Bowing my head to the glorious guru,
The Blood-Drinker (Heruka) who shakes the three worlds,
I shall set out in brief the rite that was taught,
His peaceful means of accomplishment.

The hero, with one face and two arms,
Embraced about the neck by Nairātmyā,
Endowed with ornaments such as the wheel,
Three-eyed, and wearing a skirt of tiger skin.

The yogin who is entitled to meditate in this tantra should rise at dawn and sit on a comfortable seat. Visualizing in his own heart a hūṃ resting on a sun, by its light rays he should make glorious Heruka manifest before him, and worship him properly with the five offerings, beginning with flowers. In his presence he confesses his misdeeds, rejoices in merit, and goes for refuge to the Three, and then he generates the mind set on great awakening.

He should meditate on loving-kindness, which wishes to establish all sentient beings in happiness; on compassion, which wishes to free them from all

suffering; on joy, which wishes their happiness to be surely unbroken; and on emptiness, one in character with nondual wisdom, whose nature, like the center of the stainless autumn sky, is unsullied by the stains of conceptual thought, such as all the afflictions, the secondary afflictions, and the grasped and the grasper. He should bless this with the mantra oṃ śūnyatājñānavajrasvabhāva ātmako'haṃ.

Then, rising, he visualizes in the sky a hūṃ resting on a sun maṇḍala. From its transformation comes a vajra, and on a sun at the vajra's hub he should imagine a hūṃ. Its light streams out from the mouth, accomplishes the aims of all beings without exception in the form of glorious Heruka, and enters back into it. From its transformation arises glorious Heruka, seated on a sun maṇḍala upon a corpse, on a lotus with variegated petals. He has one face, two arms and three eyes. In his right hand he holds a vajra, and in his left a skull cup marked with a vajra. He stands in a dancing posture and wears a skirt of tiger skin. On the crown of his head he bears a wheel made of human heads, which is the embodiment of Akṣobhya. At his ears he has earrings of human bone, the embodiment of Amitābha. At his neck he has a necklace, whose nature is Ratnasambhava. On his hands he has bracelets, whose nature is Vairocana. At his waist he is adorned with a girdle, the embodiment of Amoghasiddhi. He is adorned with a hair ornament, armlets and anklets, and his yellow hair bristles upward. Nairātmyā, with one face and two arms, holding a curved knife and a skull cup, embraces him about the neck.

Having imagined himself as having become such, he should imagine that he is blessed: at the ears by Nairātmyā, at the eyes by Vajrā, at the nose by Guhyagaurī, at the tongue by Vāriyoginī, at the body by Vajraḍākinī, and at the mind by Nairātmyā.

Then, at the crown of the head, at the center of a lotus of thirty-two petals, is a haṃ facing downward. At the throat, on a lotus of sixteen petals, is an aṃ facing upward. At the heart, at the center of a lotus of eight petals, is a hūṃ facing downward. At the navel, on a lotus of sixty-four petals, he should imagine an aṃ facing upward.

Then he invites the wisdom being, which is like the pledge being, and with the mantra jaḥ hūṃ vaṃ hoḥ he summons it, draws it in, binds it, and brings it under control. He should make them one in taste, like water and milk mixed together.

After this, at his own heart there is a vajra on a sun, and at its hub, by the light of a hūṃ, he summons glorious Heruka, the embodiment of all the Tathāgatas, makes offerings to him, and supplicates: "May all the Tathāgatas empower me!" They confer empowerment with jeweled vases filled with the five nectars, and he should imagine himself as having the crown ornament of the Lord Akṣobhya. Then he imagines that the whole assembly of yoginīs worships him with the substance of their own awakening mind (bodhicitta).

Then he should praise with these words:

Baring your fangs, greatly terrifying,
Adorned with a garland of mantra flowers,
Partaking fully of the great flesh,
Heruka, I bow to you and praise you.

Then, at the heart, from the transformation of a hūṃ comes a vajra, and beneath it, from the transformation of an oṃ, he generates a lotus vessel. In its center he should imagine the pledge substances, go ku da ha na ma ra mu su bi and the rest, marked with an oṃ. Then, by the union of vajra and lotus, the blazing fire burns the substances, boils them, and they melt. Regarding them as the nature of all the Tathāgatas, he summons the nectar of all the Tathāgatas by the light of the blazing sun of wisdom, the seed of wisdom, and joins it with those substances. He should bless it with the syllables oṃ āḥ hūṃ. Then, having purified his tongue as the nature of a white hūṃ, he should satisfy himself with it.

Then, at the heart, around the hūṃ resting on a sun, he mentally writes the garland of the twelve-syllable mantra oṃ trailokyākṣepa hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ svāhā, blazing and clear like a garland of lamps, and he should recite it without alteration, in the order in which it is read.

At noon and in the evening too, he instantly generates himself as the nature of Heruka. Then he performs the purification of the eyes and so forth, the meditation on the wheel, the offering, the praise, the tasting of the nectar, the recitation and the rest. Having remained in this way, he should request the deities to depart, and should perform the casting of the torma and the rest. Then, dissolving the maṇḍala, he should remain at ease, emanating instantly as the deity.

By whatever merit has been gathered
From composing this unsurpassed means of accomplishment
Of the hero who shakes the three worlds,

May the world become holders of the vajra.

This completes the means of accomplishing Hevajra with one face and two arms. It was composed by the great master Sahajavilāsa, and translated by the Indian preceptor Balendraruci and the Tibetan translator Maban Chöbar.

Translator's Notes

• "Blood-Drinker" renders □□□□□□□□, the standard Tibetan rendering of Heruka. Where the four immeasurables might be expected, the text names only loving-kindness, compassion and joy before passing to emptiness; equanimity is not mentioned and has not been supplied. □□□□□□□□ in "great awakening" is read as □□□□□□□, and □□□□□□□□ of the hair as "bristling upward" (evidently □□□□□□□). The pledge substances are given in the conventional abbreviated syllables for the five meats and five nectars. "Awakening mind" offered by the yoginīs refers in this tantric context to the generative essence.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.